

Prehistoric culture

Music, art, religion, and technology all began so long ago, we can't be certain of exactly when. There are clues to early culture, however, such as ritual burial sites, which archaeologists can date.

Earliest music

Music, like art, is much older than writing, since bone flutes and other musical instruments have been made and played for more than 40,000 years.

◆ Early instrument site

Antler flute, Hohle Fels, Germany, 43,000 years ago

First jewelry

People wore jewelry more than 100,000 years ago in sites as distant as Israel and South Africa.

◆ Early jewelry site



Shell beads, Balzi Rossi, Italy

Changes in stone tools



2.4 million years ago

The earliest tools, called the Oldowan tool kit, were made by an early human species called "Handy man," or *homo habilis*, in Africa. Oldowan-style tools in Europe and Asia are much younger, made by later types of humans, including Neanderthals.

● Oldowan site



1.8 million years ago

The Acheulean tool kit of our later ancestors, such as *Homo erectus*, included a new invention—the hand ax, with a finely chiseled edge.

● Acheulean site



200,000 years ago

Mousterian tools spanned the Middle Stone Age (ended around 40,000 BCE) and included lots of specialized shapes for different jobs.

● Mousterian site



13,000 years ago

The earliest stone tools discovered in America are from the 13,000-year-old "Clovis" people.

● Clovis site

Serra de Capivara paintings, Brazil ◆

Cueva de las Manos paintings, Argentina ◆

Cueva del Milodon, Chile ●

Wicklow Pipes, Ireland ◆

Shell bead necklace, Cro-Magnon, France ◆

Lascaux Caves, France ◆

Altamira and El Castillo caves, Spain. El Castillo features the oldest known paintings, made 40,800 years ago, possibly by Neanderthals ◆

Lady of Brassempouy carving, France ◆

Ivory horse figurine, Lourdes, France ◆

Shell beads, Grotte des Pigeons, Morocco ◆

Algerian Sahara ◆